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Green Care and Social Farming: Future Perspectives in Portugal

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Abstract

The Green Care and Social Agriculture (GC-SF) exist in Portugal, and its concept is emerging. The need to disseminate the GC-SF concept and the creation of an arena for sharing experiences and to demonstrate the need for a political and legal framework that allows the interaction between the sectors of Agriculture, Health, Welfare and Justice, led ESAC and APCC to the organization of the First Meeting of Social Agriculture at Coimbra, Portugal in April 15, 2011. This meeting was an opportunity to share the international and national experiences among participants, and provide a national feedback about GC-SF. For this reason during the conference it was requested to the participants to answer a small questionnaire. The feedback form include some of the following questions: what are the benefits, the opportunities and the barriers of green care in Portugal?

What are the main questions in this area? A number of new ideas, questions and approaches result from the answers, indicating the importance of GC-SF in Portugal. This paper will present this data and also highlight the challenges faced by GC-SF actors in Portugal.

Introduction

State of the art of Social Farming in Portugal

In the past few years the concept of Social Farming had been introduced in Portugal. In spite of being a new concept there are several Social Farming practitioners for a long time. During the COST Action 866 – Green Care in Agriculture, Pedro Mendes Moreira, as the Portuguese MC in the action, started a national survey and identified several case studies of Social Farming in Portugal. One of the biggest gaps found was the lack of interaction between those institutions (Mendes Moreira *et al.*, 2008).

Currently there are at least two European projects in the Social Farming area with Portuguese partners. The MAIE project “Multifunctional Agriculture in Europe – Social and Ecological Impacts on Organic Farms” with representatives from seven European countries that aims to develop ways of spreading knowledge about Social Farming. The main objectives of the project are qualification, network and link, spread knowledge and support rural areas through Multifunctional Agriculture – Social Farming (www.maie-project.eu). The project DIANA “Disability in Sustainable Agriculture: a New Approach for training of practitioners” unites social scientist and farm professionals and it is related to the training of practitioners who works with mental or psychiatric disabled employed on agriculture. The aim of the project Diana is to develop an integrated and joint training programme for practitioners in order to make them able to face the complex reality of Social Farming (www.projectdiana.eu).

In April 2011 the Escola Superior Agrária de Coimbra in cooperation with the Cerebral Palsy Association of Coimbra, framed in the meeting of DIANA project organized the First Meeting of Social Farming in Portugal (<http://webgrau.weebly.com/encontro-agricultura-social.html>). During the meeting we had the opportunity to have lectures from several experts in Social Farming to share experiences from different European countries and also from Portuguese practitioners. The main goal of this meeting was to joint all interested parties and to create recognition to the concept of Social Farming, trying to connect all practitioners sharing their experiences and take notice of other institutions working in the same area.

The European Manifesto on the Added Value of Social Farming (Van Elsen) highlights the importance of policies on Social Farming at the European level. In Portugal there are no national

policies about Social Farming and linkage between institutions and practitioners is rare. Hence initiatives are needed to stimulate the discussion about Social Farming between stakeholders and their links to a multifunctional approach of Agriculture, trying to put it on the political and public agenda. This arena of discussion could possibly be operationalized with the help of different programmes like Leader+ and PRODER (www.proder.pt) (rural development) or established networks – (national rural network - www.rederural.pt) could be carried out for projects of Social Farming.

In Portugal we are in a point of new challenges in the area of Social Farming, we need innovations to integrate the sectors of agriculture and social services. Taking the example of countries with a Social Farming sector more developed is necessary to understand the development of Social Farming initiatives and sector (Hassink, n.d.). This author focuses on the importance of innovation, social network, niche management, social and institutional entrepreneurship, implementation and development of new organizations. It is important to integrate different approaches and inputs.

It is important to discuss new concepts and policies in the health and social care and how can Social Farming be used within them (Sempik *et al.*, 2010). The main topics that could be analysed are physical health, mental health, outdoor spaces for education, rehabilitation, social inclusion, therapy and the cost of Green Care and Social Farming compared with other forms of social care.

The aim of the present work intended to analyse the questionnaire obtained from the participants of the First Meeting of Social Agriculture in Portugal, having the background questions: what are the benefits, opportunities and barriers for Social Farming in Portugal? In what stage of SF-GC are we?

Material and Methods

Data was collected through the distribution of questionnaires with open questions to participants of the First Meeting of Social Farming in April First 2011; at the end of the meeting 22 participants delivered the fulfilled questionnaire. The topics contained in the questionnaire were: the benefits, opportunities and barriers of Social Farming. The sample was composed around 70 per cent women and 30 per cent men.

Results and discussion

It is important to note that only 60 per cent of the respondents already had knowledge about the concept of Social Farming before the meeting, mainly through the participation in projects, practitioners and internet research.

Motivations

Regarding the motivations of inquiries on Social Farming 36 per cent of the inquiries refers to agriculture as the main sector of interest in the area of Social Farming, specifically the potential of the agriculture as a starting point to consolidate the communities, to increase the environmental, social and mental resilience. The survey also shows the lack of information about Social Farming with 31 per cent of inquiries stating that the main reason to go to the meeting was to learn and share experiences and about 18 per cent were practitioners.

Benefits

The health benefits are recognized by 68 per cent of the inquiries, they attribute to Social Farming therapeutic capacity of producing psychological and physical improvements to practitioners. It is a way to inspire and develop social and personal competences, responsibility and work habits, to do interventions and therapy. Practitioners recognise that users have several characteristics that are improved like: the raise of self-esteem, dignity, personal valorisation. It is also mentioned the reduction of relapses, re-internments, dislocations to hospital emergency and medication dosages in psychiatric institutions.

One of the benefits recognised by the majority of the respondents (55 per cent) to Social Farming is capacity to enhance capabilities of people usually marginalised by society and the capacity of inclusion and integration in the society. The potential to provide to people with some limitations, unemployed, in a precarious situation, a useful occupation and a sense of ability and contribution, to make the interaction between the individual, with social disadvantage, and the community through agriculture, for example regarding the possibility of using the food production for subsistence. Dessein et al. (2010) state that Green Care is expected to offer new solutions and to respond to specific problems in the areas of agriculture, health care and society. Through the answers we can see that respondents consider that Social Farming provides a valuable link to social integration and in medium-term can be a catalyst of social change/transformation.

Another important benefit of Social Farming is the capacity to create synergies with the environment (27 per cent), reconnect people with natural cycles through agriculture, to provide improved environmental services like the increase of biodiversity. The rediscovery of interpersonal

and environment relations promoted by Social Farming – valuation of these relations ahead of purely economic concerns. Social Farming lead us to a bigger and better human and environmental health, it raises environmental and ecological consciousness. Accordingly to 23 per cent of the inquiries another important benefit is the production of abundance and consequently improves the quality of life, it is a possibility to have an additional income. To become possible the rehabilitation of agriculture in a more sustainable way, make it solid and resilient to future changes.

Regarding the inquiries opinion (18 per cent), Social Farming can be a way to recover abandoned rural and urban areas (urban agriculture); can be a way to revive degraded rural areas mainly because it can be a powerful instrument that allows an agriculture recreation in functions and forms. The results show that 14 per cent of the answers about benefits are related to the community. Social Farming is seen as promoter of social diversity. It builds links and strengthens community and local economy precisely through the approximation of community to food production with a pedagogical and therapeutic nature of agricultural work.

Opportunities

Social Farming is a new concept that can help to redefine old concepts like economy and wealth. In the area of the opportunities 36 per cent of the answers were related with environment, referring that it can contribute to create better environment, as the recovering of degraded areas, the use of nature friendly agricultural practices, like organic farming. In addition it can give opportunities to a large number of people, in a sustainable way towards local development. People identify Social Farming as a practice that raise the income of an institution or at personal level, and that leads to an improvement of the living conditions to the more needed people, as self-production systems of healthy food through the use of friendly agricultural practices. It allows an equilibrated way of live and a happier and healthy society.

27 per cent of the respondents find opportunities in social area: social insertion and inclusion, employment, through the creation of inter personal relationships; it can also be an efficient method to fight the depopulation of rural areas. New employment related with a new area.

The survey shows that 23 per cent of respondents can find opportunities in Social Farming, especially to the maintenance of traditional farming systems, to the recuperation and reactivation of uncultivated areas, one opportunity of a sustainable approach of agriculture. It creates also the opportunity for people to be in contact with agriculture and animal production. Social Farming will

be a model of therapy for all practitioners that work with specific groups (e.g. disadvantage, elder, psychiatric).

The opportunities in health and therapeutic areas were referred by 18 per cent of inquiries. There are opportunity to individual therapy, namely in mentally disabled area that can lead to rehabilitation and inclusion. Used as an alternative to conventional therapeutic methods it shows more efficient results, observed from practitioners.

Barriers

One of the big barriers identified by inquiries (40 per cent) is regulation and bureaucracy; these barriers are translated in difficulties on the development of integrated activities. The majority of Social Farming institutions depend on funds from the government, the lack of policies in Social Farming is a problem in the recognition of the institutions and consequently on the attribution of subsidies. The lack of legal recognition makes the organization of practitioners to be very complicated and creates difficulties also at the implementation level.

The mentalities changing limitation is considered a barrier by 32 per cent of the participants. Some aspects of relevance enounced were: the lack of ethics concerning nature, the natural challenges of the work with people in disadvantage situations, (des)information from the public about Social Farming – prejudice, the underestimated value of the agricultural sector as a minor activity, the enormous spread of agricultural production and the lack of education and information of farmers, lack of civic consciousness.

Inquires identify the lack of coordination between competences another important barrier to break (18 per cent). The problems created are the lack of double skills from the practitioners, the lack of a cohesive body to provide the framework for Social Farming, with educational, agricultural, informative and monitoring valences.

The 14 per cent of inquiries consider the lack of support in the conception, implementation, monitoring of Social Farming projects one big barrier to the development of that area.

Conclusions

In Portugal there are people interested in Social Farming implementation. Taking in consideration the limited number of enquires, and also that people who participate were interested on the topic. A preliminary approach can be draw for future decisions. Data from enquires, indicates that 40 per cent of the respondents never had heard about the Social Farming concept before the meeting.

The main motivations of the respondents in the meeting were, to share experiences and learn or to be practitioners.

Health was recognised by the majority (68 per cent) of respondents, as a benefit associated with Social Farming. Other benefits recognised are the capacity to enhance capabilities of people marginalised by society, the power of inclusion and integration, the capacity to create synergies with the environment that can also be a tool for environmental preservation and conservation.

Concerning opportunities of Social Farming environment implementation and organic agriculture were the more referred areas. The social area with topics related with social inclusion was also seen as a good opportunity.

We can say that the biggest barrier for Social Farming in Portugal is at the political level, bureaucracy, lack of legislation and regulation to facilitate the implementation of the initiatives. It is also needed a mentality exchange, in order to create in the general population a credibility to Social Farming. The lack of coordination between competences and education of practitioners is another important issue that was identified in the questionnaires as problem to break.

After the meeting and the analysis of the questionnaires we can say that there is space in the Portuguese reality to Social Farming. During the meeting the participants were enthusiastic, and after they understand better what kind of initiatives is possible to integrate in the Social Farming concept.

Now in Portugal, and worldwide we are facing an economic crises, can Social Farming be a good contribute to help facing some economic issues?

One thing is very clear, we really need to put Social Farming in the political agenda and to legislate and cooperate within practitioners.

It will be very interesting to explore the GC and Social farming in the ambit of Social Economy (as a transversal and multisectorial approach) as a response to the social and economic actual context, creating new paradigms and solutions.

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